DNA for the party to turn away from it. Its position today is not too far away from the idea expressed by Advani in 1991 that India is 'essentially a Hindu country'.[71] Yogi Adityanath and Amit Shah's politics especially exemplify this. When questioned about whether he would attend a similar ceremony for a mosque in Ayodhya as he did for the Ram Temple, the UP chief minister was unequivocal: 'If you ask me as a chief minister, then I don't abstain from any religion or community. But if you ask me as a yogi, then I will definitely not go. I will not go because I am a Hindu. As a Hindu, I have a right to worship and lead life as per the laid religious rules. But I don't have the right to intervene in others' works or meddle into others' affairs.'[72] The statement also reflected the BJP's current understanding that Hindutva had been a necessary condition for the party to grow. At another level, the Taliban's conquest of Kabul in 2021, and its establishment of a hardline sharia-based state in Afghanistan, strengthens the seeding power of Hindu nationalist messaging. It is too early to say how this will pan out, but the Taliban's ascent has already become a cipher for global jihad in many debates at the local political level.

Each time the BJP has focused on sharpening its position on Hindutva, the party's ranks have swelled. Every time it has waffled on this issue, after the 1990s phase of consolidation under Vajpayee, for instance, it has entered into periods of decline. Yet, Hindutva positioning has never been sufficient on its own to win elections, as this book has documented. Hindutva was the engine that gave it electoral momentum, but election victories were fashioned by creating a unique cocktail of Hinduness, caste reengineering and a deep focus on welfarism. In short, as a UP government official working closely with Yogi Adityanath told me, Hindutva gave the BJP's wheel speed, but the wheel that drove its expansion was welfare.[73] 'Welfare' or 'development' here refers specifically to the government's focus on cash transfers through a dozen-plus schemes, not 'hard infrastructure'. The embracing of this system is what created the new BJP system of politics.

Yet, it is undeniable that Hindutva provided the glue that held together the party's core supporters and informed its recasting of secularism after 2014. As then Home Minister Rajnath Singh told the